

Adult Transition Starter Kit

You gathered the documents and made the plan with the Checklist Worksheet. This kit is the next step onto your child's future: how to actually do each part, one step at a time, in plain language.

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How this kit works: Each part takes one item from your worksheet and walks you through it — what it is, why it matters, and the exact steps to get it done. Keep your completed Checklist Worksheet beside you as you go. You do not have to do everything at once. Most families work through one part a month.

Inside this kit: 1) Your Transition Timeline • 2) Social Security at 18 • 3) Medicaid & Texas Waivers • 4) Guardianship or Supported Decision-Making • 5) Money That Protects Benefits (ABLE & Trusts) • 6) Work & Day Life • 7) Housing & Daily Life • 8) Your Letter of Intent (fill-in) • 9) One-Page Medical & Emergency Summary (fill-in) • 10) When Things Go Wrong

Part 1 — Your Transition Timeline

Adulthood does not start at 18 — it is built in the years before. Use this timeline to see where you are and what comes next.

Age	What to focus on
14-16	Transition goals in the IEP. First transition assessments. Get on Texas waiver interest lists NOW — the wait can be years. Start a records binder.
16-17	Decide how decisions will be made at 18 (Part 4). Open an ABLE account (Part 5). Practice daily-living skills. Explore work experience and Vocational Rehabilitation.
17½	Gather SSI records — medical, school, function evidence. You can start the SSI process about 6 months before the 18th birthday in many cases; ask Social Security for the earliest date to file.
At 18	SSI is decided again under ADULT rules. Apply for adult Medicaid. Your child is a legal adult — schools, doctors, and agencies will treat them as one.
18-22	School services can continue to 22 in Texas if the student has not finished their program. Build work, day programs, and community life. Keep waivers, Medicaid renewals, and records current every year.

Part 2 — Social Security at 18 (SSI)

If your child received SSI as a child — or never applied — everything is looked at again at 18 under the adult rules. The adult question is different: it is not only about the diagnosis. Social Security asks whether your child's condition keeps them from doing substantial work, and whether it has lasted (or will last) at least 12 months.

Step 1 — Build the file before you apply

Use your worksheet: medical records, school records (IEPs, evaluations, teacher statements), therapy records, and your own written notes about daily life. Ask providers for copies early — offices can be slow.

Step 2 — Write the function story

The most important evidence is often the everyday story: what your child can and cannot do in daily living, communication, behavior, learning, safety, and supervision. Write real examples with dates. Be honest and complete — describe a hard day, not the best day.

Step 3 — File the application

Start at ssa.gov or by calling Social Security at 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778) to begin the claim. Answer everything, list every doctor, school, and treatment, and keep copies of everything you send.

Step 4 — Cooperate and keep records current

Social Security may schedule a consultative exam with their doctor — go, and be on time. Keep medical care going during the wait; gaps in treatment can hurt a claim. Tell Social Security about any changes.

Step 5 — Know the timeline — and the appeals

A first decision commonly takes about 3 to 6 months, but it can take longer. If denied, you generally have 60 days to appeal (reconsideration first, then a hearing in front of a judge). Many strong cases are won on appeal — a denial is not the end. Keep appealing on time.

Money basics: SSI has income and resource rules. The resource limit is \$2,000 for an individual (not counting the home you live in, one vehicle in most cases, and money in an ABLE account up to \$100,000). That is why Parts 5 of this kit — ABLE accounts and trusts — matters so much.

Part 3 — Medicaid & Texas Waivers

Medicaid is the health coverage most adults with disabilities rely on, and waiver programs pay for help at home and in the community that regular Medicaid does not. Two rules to live by: never let Medicaid lapse, and get on waiver interest lists as early as you can.

Step 1 — Protect the Medicaid you have

Do the annual renewal every year, on time, and report address changes right away. A missed renewal letter is one of the most common ways families lose coverage.

Step 2 — Apply for adult Medicaid at 18

Children's Medicaid does not simply continue. At 18, eligibility is looked at under adult rules, often through the SSI decision. Apply through YourTexasBenefits.com or by calling 2-1-1.

Step 3 — Get on the waiver interest lists

Call and ask to be placed on the interest lists for HCS, CLASS, DBMD, and TxHmL. In Texas you can start with 2-1-1 or your Local Intellectual and Developmental Disability Authority (LIDDA). Write down the date you called and the name of the person you spoke with — keep it in your worksheet.

Step 4 — Stay reachable while you wait

Waiver waits in Texas can be many years. If your phone number or address changes, update it with the interest list, or you can lose your place. When your name comes up, respond quickly and completely.

Step 5 — If services are reduced later

Once your adult child has waiver services, attend the annual planning meetings, review the service plan, and appeal reductions you do not agree with — you have that right, and deadlines apply.

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Part 4 — Guardianship or Supported Decision-Making

At 18, your child becomes a legal adult in Texas — even if they still need a lot of help. Schools and doctors will look to THEM for signatures and decisions unless something is put in place. You have options, and full guardianship is not the only one.

Supported Decision-Making (least restrictive): Your adult child keeps their rights and chooses trusted supporters to help them understand choices and communicate decisions. Texas was the first state to recognize Supported Decision-Making Agreements in law. This works well for many young adults.

Limited guardianship: A court gives a guardian only certain powers (for example, medical or financial), and your adult child keeps the rest of their rights.

Full guardianship: A court gives the guardian broad decision-making power. This is the most restrictive option and should be used only when truly necessary.

Simple tools that help almost every family: HIPAA release so doctors can talk with you, school consent forms, a medical power of attorney, and a durable power of attorney — as appropriate for your child's abilities.

Start at 16-17, and use a professional: Guardianship is a court process. Work with a Texas attorney who handles guardianship and special needs planning. Southern Oak can help you understand the options and prepare your questions, but we are not attorneys and cannot file for you.

Part 5 — Money That Protects Benefits (ABLE & Trusts)

The \$2,000 SSI resource limit means a well-meant gift or an inheritance can accidentally stop benefits. These two tools exist so families can save safely.

ABLE accounts — the savings account that does not count (up to a point)

- ☐ Who can open one: a person whose disability began before age 46. Only one ABLE account per person.
- ☐ How it works: family and the account owner can contribute (there is a yearly contribution limit, roughly the IRS gift-tax amount — check the current number when you open it). The first \$100,000 in the account does not count toward the SSI resource limit.
- ☐ What it can pay for: housing, transportation, education, health, assistive technology, employment support, and other disability-related expenses.
- ☐ How to open: Texas families can use the Texas ABLE program (texasable.org) or another state's program. You open it online with basic information and a first deposit.

Special Needs Trusts — for larger amounts and inheritances

Third-party trust: set up by parents or family, funded with THEIR money or inheritance.

The most common planning tool — it can hold a home, money, or life insurance proceeds for your child's extra needs.

First-party trust: funded with your child's OWN money (for example, a settlement or back benefits). Has stricter rules, including payback to Medicaid at the end.

Pooled trust: run by a nonprofit that pools many families' accounts. Often the practical choice for smaller amounts.

The golden rule: update your will, your life insurance beneficiaries, and grandparents' plans so money flows into the trust — never directly to your child. A special needs attorney should draft the trust; this kit is education, not legal advice.

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Part 6 — Work & Day Life

A full life needs full days. Whether the goal is a job, training, college, or a day program, plan it on purpose — do not wait for it to happen.

Step 1 — Open a Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) case

Texas Workforce Solutions — Vocational Rehabilitation Services helps people with disabilities prepare for, find, and keep jobs. Ask the school to invite VR to transition meetings before graduation, and apply early. VR can help pay for training, evaluations, job coaching, and more.

Step 2 — Build experience in small steps

Volunteering, school work programs, internships, and Project SEARCH (a school-to-work program hosted in businesses) all count. Real experience before graduation makes adult employment far more likely.

Step 3 — Use support at work

Supported employment and job coaches can train your adult child on the job and then fade back as skills grow. Many waiver programs can help pay for this support.

Step 4 — Learn the work incentives

Earning money does not automatically end SSI or Medicaid — there are work incentive rules that let benefits step down gradually, and students under 22 have an extra earnings exclusion. Get the current rules explained before turning work out of fear.

Step 5 — If college or training is the goal

Every college has a disability support office. Register early, bring documentation, and ask about accommodations. VR funding may help with costs.

Part 7 — Housing & Daily Life

Most young adults start adulthood at home — that is normal. The goal of this part is a plan for what comes next, at your family's pace.

Family home with supports: waiver services, attendants, and respite brought into your home.

Host home / companion care: living with a screened provider family, supported by an agency (often through HCS).

Supported living / group home: a small shared home with staff support, usually through a waiver.

Own apartment with supports: with Section 8 or other housing help, drop-in support, and technology. Housing waitlists are long too — apply early, and keep applications updated.

Keep building skills at home: cooking, laundry, money, safety, and transportation practice now will pay off in every future housing option. Use Part 7 of your Checklist Worksheet to track progress.

Part 8 — Your Letter of Intent (Fill-In)

A Letter of Intent is not a legal document — it is your care plan in your own words, so anyone who steps in can care for your child the way you do. Fill it in, keep it with your will and trust, and update it every year.

My child's full name, nickname, and date of birth

The people who know my child best (family, friends, faith community)

Doctors, therapists, and pharmacy — with phone numbers

Medications — what, when, and how my child takes them

Allergies and medical conditions responders must know

A normal day — wake-up, meals, school/work, evening, bedtime routines

Foods my child loves — and foods to avoid

How my child communicates, and how to understand them

What calms my child when they are upset, scared, or in pain

Behaviors to watch for, and what they usually mean

Favorite activities, people, places, and celebrations

Religious, cultural, and family traditions that matter

My hopes and dreams for my child's adult life

Where important documents are kept

Part 9 — One-Page Medical & Emergency Summary (Fill-In)

Fill this page in, copy it, and keep copies in the emergency go-bag, the car, and with your child's school or program. It speaks for your child when you cannot.

Name / Date of birth / Height & weight

Diagnoses and conditions

Allergies (medicines, foods, latex)

Current medications and doses

Doctors and specialists — names and phone numbers

Hospital of choice / Insurance information

Communication — how my child expresses pain and needs

Behavioral notes — what helps in a crisis

Emergency contacts — 1st, 2nd, and 3rd choice, with phone numbers

Legal decision-maker (guardian / supporter) and how to reach them

Emergency kit checklist: go-bag with 3 days of medication, copies of this summary and insurance cards, a change of clothes, comfort items, charger, and a written crisis plan. Register with your local emergency and paratransit programs if available.

Part 10 — When Things Go Wrong

An SSI denial is not the end. You usually have 60 days to appeal. File on time even if you are still gathering records — deadlines protect your claim date.

Keep paper proof of everything. Copies of applications, letters, and notes of every phone call (date, time, who you spoke with, what they said).

Watch the mail. Most benefit problems start with a missed letter. Open agency mail the day it arrives and calendar every deadline.

Ask for help early. Southern Oak helps families prepare SSA applications and understand their options. Email supporthelpsofw@gmail.com or visit southernoakfw.org. For court

matters and legal documents, work with a qualified Texas special needs attorney.

You are building a future, one step at a time. The families who do best are not the ones who do everything perfectly — they are the ones who start early, keep records, and keep going. Southern Oak is proud to walk beside you.

Please read: This kit is an educational guide only. It is not legal, tax, medical, or financial advice, and Southern Oak Financial & Wellness is not a law firm and does not provide legal representation. Program rules, limits, phone numbers, and websites change — confirm current details with the agency before you act. There is no guarantee of approval for any benefit, waiver, or program; the agencies and programs make those decisions. Trusts and guardianship require a qualified attorney. This kit is for your family's personal use only — no refunds.

The Adult Transition Starter Kit pairs with the Special Needs Adult Transition Planning Checklist Worksheet, available at southernoakfw.org.

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